hysterical. Paper torches were lit all round the stands, creating an unbelievable atmosphere. I felt a sense of exhilaration and was soon engulfed by my team-mates. It was one of the best one-day internationals I had played in.

The other, rather unexpected, contributor to the Indian victory was a mongoose, which kept coming onto the ground during the second half of this day-night encounter at the Eden Gardens. It seemed that every time the mongoose came on the field the momentum shifted and the South Africans lost a wicket. While it was just a coincidence, of course, it turned out to be a lucky coincidence for India!

After such a nerve-racking semi-final, the final was a relatively easy affair, with Anil running through the West Indies line-up to give us the title. He bowled brilliantly and finished off with career-best figures of 6–12 as we won the Hero Cup in front of a packed Eden Gardens. To make the victory even sweeter, I managed to get the wicket of Brian Lara. Getting Brian Lara out was interesting because Ajit, who had travelled to Kolkata with me to watch the semi-final and the final, had mentioned to me in the hotel that I should look to get Brian Lara out if I got a chance to bowl to him, and also suggested that I should bowl stump to stump to him. As it happened, I did get a chance to bowl to Brian, who had opened the batting for the West Indies. After he had hit me for a few runs, I bowled him a delivery slightly outside the off stump, which nipped back in a shade and bowled him. Delighted with the wicket, I immediately thought of the discussion I had had with Ajit.

My first year of cricket on home soil had gone really well. However, there were still things I desperately wanted to do. One was getting my first ODI hundred and another was opening the batting for India in one-dayers.

India in New Zealand, March–April 1994

It was the morning of 27 March 1994 and later that day we were playing New Zealand in the second game of a four-match ODI series in Auckland. Navjot Sidhu, our first-choice opener, woke up with a stiff neck and was in no position to play. That’s when I went up to Azhar and our manager Ajit Wadekar, a former Indian captain and a leading batsman of his time, and pleaded with them to give me an opportunity at the top of the order. Why did I think I should open? Well, I had the